

The Enlightenment

The German philosopher Immanuel Kant described the Enlightenment as “... man’s release from his self-inflicted immaturity,” meaning that people should use their reason without taking direction. His motto, *Sapere aude!* (“Dare to know!”) encouraged readers to challenge outdated traditions.

The Enlightenment was an intellectual “current” that flowed across Europe and beyond during the 18th century thanks to an explosion in printing and the widespread use of the French language. The thinkers, known as *philosophes*, applied ideas from advances in science (see pp.266–67) to change the way that people thought about government and society, seeking to replace superstition, tyranny, and injustice with reason, tolerance, and legal equality.

From 1750, a “republic of letters” emerged in Paris, aided by the existence of literary salons and the *Encyclopédie* (see right). “What does it mean to be free?” asked Francois-Marie Arouet—better known as Voltaire—probably the most famous *philosophe* of them all. “To reason correctly and know the rights of man. When they are well known, they are well defended.”

Questioning received wisdom led the *philosophes* to attack many things: general ignorance and intolerance;

outdated privilege among nobles and clergy; absolutism or tyranny in all its forms, such as the royal *lettres de cachet* that allowed anyone to be locked up without evidence; and the Church (for encouraging superstition and persecution).

The Swiss thinker Jean-Jacques Rousseau railed against moral decadence and inequality in his essays on *The Arts and Sciences* (1749) and on *Equality* (1755), which challenged basic Enlightenment beliefs by arguing that social progress had helped to corrupt human nature. His

bestselling novels *La Nouvelle Heloise* (1761) and *Emile* (1762) tapped into a rich vein of “sentimentalism” and made him the darling of the chattering classes. But he soon found himself an isolated figure, in conflict with other *philosophes*.

Spreading ideas

The most influential tool for spreading Enlightenment values was the 28-volume *Encyclopédie*, which boasted an impressive array of contributors, including Jacques Turgot, Voltaire,

The *Encyclopédie* (1751–72)

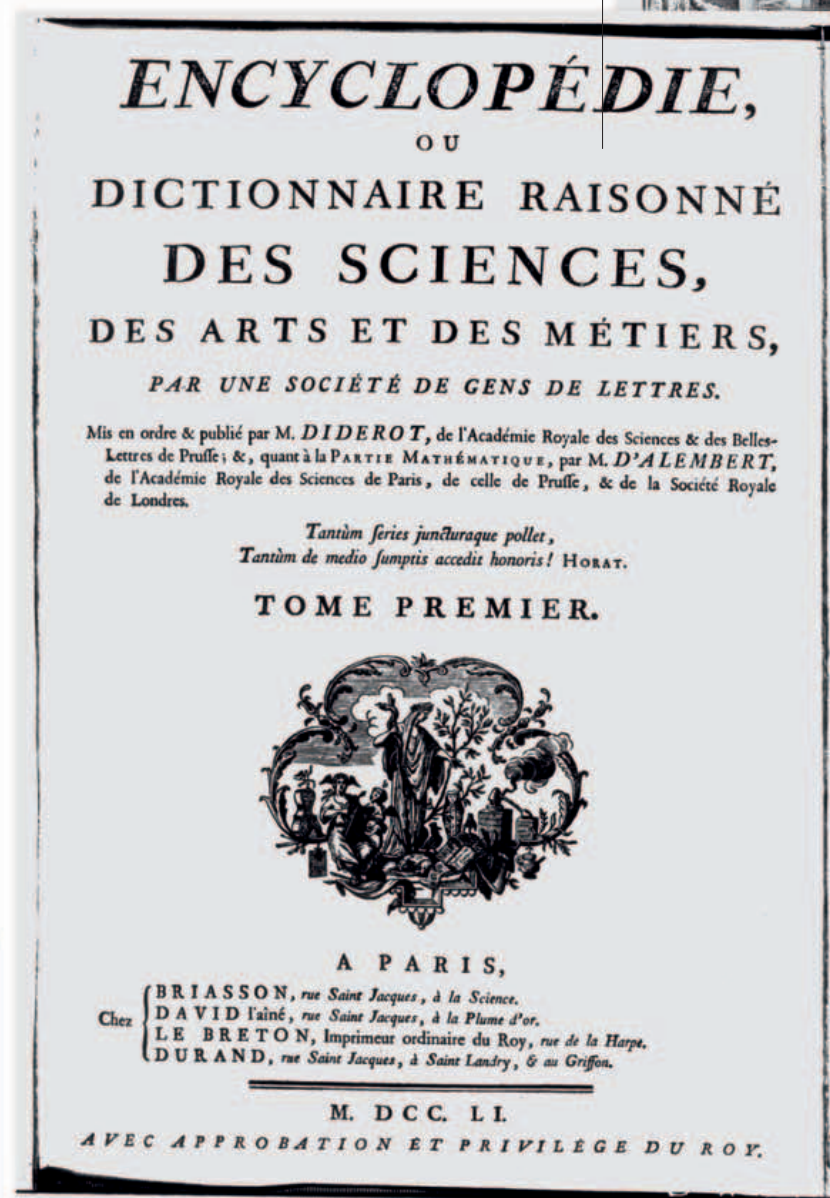
Diderot and d’Alembert edited this 28-volume magnum opus over 20 years. Its 17 volumes of text and 11 volumes of engravings contained 72,000 articles and over 2,500 plates.

Frontispiece for the first volume of the *Encyclopédie* or “Reasoned Dictionary of the Sciences, Arts and Trades.”



Madame de Pompadour

A woman renowned for her beauty and wit, Jeanne Poisson (1721–64) was installed in Versailles Palace as Louis XV’s mistress. She was an avid patron of artistic and intellectual projects.



The roots of the Enlightenment lay in the Renaissance and English political and intellectual culture.

HUMANISM

A cultural movement of the Renaissance

◀ 250–53, humanism laid the foundations for the Enlightenment by emphasizing the dignity and reason of man. Humanists such as the French moralist Michel de Montaigne wrote essays questioning anything and everything.

POLITICAL REFORMS

In 1688, the English king James II was overthrown and replaced by William III. Subsequent political reforms inspired French writers, such

as Voltaire. He promoted the English legal system, religious toleration, and its constitutional monarchy as alternatives to French absolutism in his *Lettres Philosophiques* (1734); it was immediately banned.

ENGLISH ROOTS

Enlightenment thinkers adopted three English philosophers as their “patron saints”: Francis Bacon (1561–1626) for his development of scientific method based on experiment and observation; John Locke (1632–1704) for his political theory and empiricism (acceptance of knowledge based only on direct experience); and Isaac Newton (1643–1727) for his unifying scientific laws and discoveries.

FRANCIS BACON’S “THE ADVANCEMENT OF LEARNING”



and Rousseau under the editorial guidance of Denis Diderot and Jean d’Alembert. Its aim was to assemble and disseminate all existing knowledge in clear, accessible prose and to educate public opinion by “changing accepted habits of thought.” Banned twice for its anti-Catholic tone, its survival relied on the support of the state censor.

A more effective way of spreading similar ideas was through satire. The

political theorist Montesquieu started this trend with *Lettres Persanes* (1721), which depicted French and European customs through the eyes of Persian visitors, poking fun at the Church, Court, and French society. Voltaire perfected it in *Candide* (1759), an account of a naïve young man’s adventures, by exposing the hypocrisies of the institutions and attitudes that he encountered.



MONTAIGNE’S “ESSAYS”